

• A FIELD KIT FOR WHOEVER OWNS THE OFFSITE

Everything you need to run a *leadership offsite*.

Handed the offsite and not sure where to start? This is the kit that makes you look like you've run a dozen — the questions, the agenda, the checklist, the budget, the follow-through. All of it ready to edit.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 1 Three principles we design every retreat around
- 2 Five questions to align with your sponsor
- 3 The agenda: its shape, and what goes in it
- 4 The venue & logistics checklist
- 5 A prep timeline
- 6 A budget worksheet
- 7 What to do after — the 30 days that decide it

The offsite isn't the point. What's still true 30 days later is.

Read pages 2–5 first. Use pages 6–11 to run it. Use page 12 to make it stick.

2,000+
EVENTS PRODUCED

4.76/5
25,000+ REVIEWS

Decide the outcome. Then choose the room.

The location and the activities are the **format**. The outcome is the **function**. The format exists to serve it, which means the outcome has to be settled first and everything else is downstream of it. Book the venue before you know the outcome and you have capped what the offsite can do before anyone arrives.

This is the step nearly everyone skips, because the venue is the thing with a deadline. Availability drives the calendar, the calendar drives the agenda, and by the time someone asks what the two days are actually for, the answer has to fit a room that was chosen for its A/V.

The environment is not the backdrop. It is an instrument — and it is doing something to the room whether you chose it deliberately or not.

DO THIS

The living room

Nine executives, one rented house, no conference table. Couches, coffee, shoes off, nobody at the head of anything. Within an hour the deference is gone — because the furniture never established it in the first place.

Right for: new thinking, trust, anything that needs candour.

NOT THIS

The boardroom

The same nine people, the same brief, their own boardroom because it was free. Their brains have solved a thousand problems in that room and know exactly what it is for: status, execution, getting through the deck. You will get their work selves.

Wrong for: anything you would describe as creative or honest.

THE TELL

If you could run your agenda over a video call without losing anything, the location is doing no work. You have paid for a room instead of an instrument — and the room is the most expensive line on page 11.

WORKED EXAMPLE

The room they had already booked

A leadership team wanted one thing from their offsite: a genuinely new answer to a problem they had been circling for a year. They had booked a hotel meeting room twenty minutes from the office — projector, U-shape, branded notepads. We moved it to a rented house with a long kitchen and two sofas. Same people, same brief, same two days. The answer arrived in the second session, from the person who had said least in the boardroom for a year. Nothing about the thinking changed. The room stopped telling them who they were supposed to be.

THE HARD PART

Not seeing this. Telling a CFO that the free boardroom is the wrong room, and holding that position through the budget conversation.

How to actually find a room that does the work.

You do not need a conference centre and you probably do not need to fly anyone. What you need is a handful of distinct spaces you are allowed to use however you like.

Start on Airbnb or VRBO — in their own city

Filter for **five or more bedrooms**. Not for the beds — for the rooms. A five-bedroom house reliably comes with three or four genuinely different areas: a living room with soft seating, a kitchen with enough places to sit, a deck or a garden, and somewhere quiet to take a call. That is four environments for less than the price of one hotel meeting room.

Search the city they are already in. If the team is not travelling anyway, do not make them — thirty minutes from the office is far enough to change the day, and a flight is rarely the upgrade it looks like on paper. Message the host and say it is a work booking; the good ones will tell you exactly which room the group will end up in.

CHECK THE LISTING FOR THESE BEFORE YOU BOOK

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Five or more bedrooms — for the rooms, not the beds | ☐ A living room you are allowed to rearrange |
| ☐ Kitchen seating for the whole group at once | ☐ Outdoor space — deck, garden, anything |
| ☐ One table everyone can get around | ☐ Parking, and a host who knows it is work |

If you genuinely cannot leave the building

The workplace can still work — but only if you refuse to spend the day in one room. Book the room nobody uses. Take the brainstorming session to a local park. Do the debrief on a walk. Eat anywhere that is not the working room. The rule was never *leave the office*. It is **do not leave them in one room all day**.

THEN KEEP MOVING

This applies to the house too. Living room for the first block, kitchen for lunch, deck for the debrief, back inside for commitments. Change the environment when you change the function — the physical move does the resetting for you, it reads as generosity rather than process, and it costs nothing.

THE HARD PART Explaining a five-bedroom house to a procurement team whose vendor form only has a box for hotels.

Inhale, exhale. Then the next inhale.

Every session does one of two things. An **inhale** asks people to take something in and give something up — vulnerability, a hard truth, a decision they have been avoiding. An **exhale** lets them put it down: food, movement, air, laughter, something to react to that is not themselves.

A retreat is a sequence of these, and the sequence matters more than the content. Two inhales back to back and the room goes flat. Nobody has anything left for the second one, so you get compliance instead of honesty — and afterwards everyone concludes the group was not ready. They were ready. They were out of breath.

An agenda made only of exhales is a nice trip. An agenda made only of inhales is an interrogation.

WHAT USUALLY GETS BUILT

Trust session ↓

The hard topic ↓

Commitments ↓

flat by 3pm

WHAT ACTUALLY WORKS

Trust session ↓

Walk outside ↑

The hard topic ↓

Lunch, made together ↑

Commitments ↓

still honest at 5

WORKED EXAMPLE

The twenty minutes you will want to cut

A team spends ninety minutes on what they do not say to each other. It goes well — which means it cost them something. The agenda says strategy starts now and you are already ten minutes behind. Send them outside for twenty anyway. They come back sharper than they left and strategy becomes the best block of the day. Cut the twenty and you will spend sixty getting nothing.

THE FAILURE IT PREVENTS

The afternoon that went flat

One-thirty: ninety minutes on trust, and it is real — two people say things they have never said at work. Three o'clock, coffee refilled, straight into the hardest strategic choice of the year. By twenty past, three people are on their phones. The CEO is filling the silence. At four they agree on something nobody owns, and everyone leaves saying the group was not ready for that conversation. The group was ready at one-thirty. Nobody let them breathe out, so there was nothing left to spend.

THE HARD PART Defending an empty twenty minutes to a room full of people who bill by the hour — while the agenda is already running late.

The building is part of the agenda.

Choose a room for its function and it arrives with things a meeting room does not have: a kitchen, a thermostat you can actually reach, a table that needs clearing, a garden, weather. Most people let all of it sit there and order catering — which wastes the most powerful facilitation tools they will have all week, precisely because none of them feel like facilitation.

Anything that makes people do something small and real together will do more for the afternoon than an exercise with a worksheet.

WORKED EXAMPLE · TRUST

The sandwich

Stock the fridge — nothing fancy, just good bread and everything that goes on it — and do not order lunch in. Everyone makes a sandwich, and nobody makes their own. Now I have to come and ask you things. Mustard or mayo? Pickles? Wheat, or a Dutch crunch roll? It is a silly conversation, and the first intimate thing we have done. You are making food I will eat, and I have told you something true about myself. So when I am asked to be honest in front of the group that afternoon, I have already practised. The barrier came down at lunch, over pickles.

WORKED EXAMPLE · CONFLICT

The thermostat

Want the conflict on the table? Turn the heat up and do not feed them. Frustrated people take off the company hat and say what they actually think instead of what they think should be said — which is usually the thing the team most needs to hear. Use it deliberately, tell nobody you are doing it, and feed them the moment it is out.

WORKED EXAMPLE · HIERARCHY

The dishes

Nobody's assistant is there. Someone has to clear up, and for twenty minutes the org chart is whoever is holding the dish towel. It is the cheapest hierarchy-breaker available, and the only thing it costs is not hiring someone to do it for you.

WHAT ALL THREE HAVE IN COMMON

The tool was already in the building and cost nothing, and nobody in the room experienced it as an exercise. That is the whole trick. The moment people can see the mechanism, it stops working — which is why these are decisions you make quietly, in advance, and never explain until afterwards.

THE HARD PART Being the person who announces that nobody makes their own sandwich — and not blinking when the room looks at you.

Align with your sponsor in five questions.

The offsites that go sideways are the ones booked before anyone agreed what they were for. Ten minutes with your exec sponsor on these five questions saves you weeks — and gives you the language to defend every decision that follows.

1 Why this offsite, why now?

What's the real reason we're pulling people out of their week?

2 What does success look like the Monday after?

One or two things that should be true when everyone's back at their desk.

3 Who is in the room — and who isn't?

4 What's off-limits? Topics, sacred cows.

5 What decision or commitment should the group leave with?

A retreat without a decision is a nice lunch. Name the outcome now.

RULE OF THUMB

The ratio that works is roughly $\frac{1}{3}$ **content**, $\frac{1}{3}$ **conversation**, $\frac{1}{3}$ **connection**. If your draft agenda is 90% presentations, you've built a conference, not a retreat.

The shape of a 1.5-day retreat.

These blocks are named by their *job* and their *breath*, not by their activity — because the activity depends on your outcome. Lock the shape here; fill it from the key on page 8.

Day 1 — arrive after lunch

TIME	BLOCK	BREATH	THE JOB OF THIS BLOCK
12:00–1:00	Arrival & lunch	↑ EXHALE	Travel ends and the group assembles. No content — resist it.
1:00–1:30	The frame	↓ INHALE	The sponsor says why we're here and what's true Monday. Permission to be candid.
1:30–3:00	Block 1 · 90 min	↓ INHALE	The first real work. Hardest thinking of the afternoon goes here.
3:00–3:30	Reset	↑ EXHALE	Move, eat, get outside. Technology break — phones allowed.
3:30–5:00	Block 2 · 90 min	↓ INHALE	Same topic or the next one. Never a third block before dinner.
5:00–6:30	Open	↑ EXHALE	Nothing scheduled. This is not wasted time.
6:30	Dinner	↑ EXHALE	No agenda, no seating chart, no toast.

Day 2 — finish by lunch

TIME	BLOCK	BREATH	THE JOB OF THIS BLOCK
8:00–8:45	Breakfast	↑ EXHALE	Slow start. Let last night carry over.
8:45–9:00	Re-frame	↓ INHALE	Where we got to, what's left. Two minutes, not ten.
9:00–10:30	Block 3 · 90 min	↓ INHALE	The hard one. Put it here — the room is warmest and sharpest.
10:30–11:00	Reset	↑ EXHALE	Outside if you can. Technology break.
11:00–12:00	Commitments	↓ INHALE	Who owns what, by when. Written down and said out loud.
12:00–12:30	Close	↑ EXHALE	Each person names one commitment. Then stop — never end on logistics.

TWO RULES THAT OVERRIDE THE CLOCK

Ninety minutes is the ceiling. After that people stop being able to focus. Come back to the same topic in the next block if you need to — but only after a break that lets them breathe out or gives them something new to react to.

No phones in blocks; phones in breaks. If you ban technology during the work you owe them real technology breaks to deal with their day. Ban it without them and you lose the room to anxiety instead of email.

What goes in the blocks.

Find your function and read across. If your outcome isn't here the pattern still holds: the environment does half the work, and the exhale is what makes the next inhale possible.

Brainstorm & new thinking

ENVIRONMENT

Anywhere they don't work. No room with whiteboard-shaped memory. Soft seating, no table between people.

THE EXHALE BETWEEN

Physical and outdoors. A walk beats coffee — new input, not more talk.

Block 1 · Load the problem. Constraints, data, what's been tried. No solving yet.

Block 2 · Diverge. Volume over quality, evaluation banned. Silent writing first.

Block 3 · Converge. Kill most of it. Name what gets tested and who tests it.

Worked when · *the idea they leave with wasn't in anyone's head on arrival.*

Trust, candour & safety

ENVIRONMENT

Domestic, not corporate. A kitchen and a living room — people out of their work posture.

THE EXHALE BETWEEN

Food they make together. The sandwich, page 5 — small intimacies before big ones.

Block 1 · A shared build or give-back. Hands busy, hierarchy off.

Block 2 · The facilitated debrief. This is the session; the activity was setup.

Block 3 · What we don't say to each other, and why. Named, not necessarily resolved.

Worked when · *someone says the thing they've carried for a year, and nothing bad happens.*

Strategy & alignment

ENVIRONMENT

Wall space and daylight. Off-site but sober: focus, not novelty.

THE EXHALE BETWEEN

Short and functional. Coffee, air, five minutes of nothing. Don't break the thread.

Block 1 · A shared picture of reality. Argue facts before choices.

Block 2 · The choice. Two or three real options with the tradeoffs said out loud.

Block 3 · What we're saying no to. Hardest 90 minutes — always after a break.

Worked when · *everyone states the strategy the same way without the deck.*

Conflict — on the table

ENVIRONMENT

You control the room. Warm, light on food, no easy exits. Discomfort is the instrument.

THE EXHALE BETWEEN

Separate them. A walk alone or in pairs — never straight into lunch together.

Block 1 · Each person says what they think is going wrong. Timed, uninterrupted, no replies yet.

Block 2 · The replies. The facilitator holds the line — this is the block that earns its money.

Block 3 · What changes Monday. Specific, owned, dated.

Worked when · *people say what they actually think instead of what they think should be said.*

Annual planning

ENVIRONMENT

Long tables, a wall you can cover, good light. Comfort beats atmosphere.

THE EXHALE BETWEEN

A real break between looking back and forward — different mental modes.

Block 1 · Look back honestly. What we said we'd do, what we did, the gap.

Block 2 · The few things that matter next year. Fewer than feels safe.

Block 3 · Sequencing and ownership. Who, by when, what gets dropped.

Worked when · *the plan has fewer items than last year's and every one has a name on it.*

The half-day shape.

One session, one outcome. Same rules apply. The common mistake is compressing a 1.5-day agenda into four hours — you keep the format and lose the function. Cut scope instead: one function, one decision.

TIME	BLOCK	BREATH	THE JOB OF THIS BLOCK
8:45–9:00	Arrive & settle	↑ EXHALE	Coffee, no content. Late arrivals cost you Block 1.
9:00–9:15	The frame	↓ INHALE	Why we're here, what's true when we leave. One person, short.
9:15–10:45	Block 1 · 90 min	↓ INHALE	The work. All of it. This block <i>is</i> the retreat.
10:45–11:15	Reset	↑ EXHALE	Outside. Technology break. Non-negotiable, especially when time is short.
11:15–12:15	Block 2 · 60 min	↓ INHALE	Converge and decide. Don't open anything new.
12:15–12:30	Commitments & close	↓ INHALE	One commitment each, out loud. Then stop.
12:30	Lunch	↑ EXHALE	Optional — and better unstructured.

Now build yours

TIME	BLOCK	BREATH	THE JOB OF THIS BLOCK

READ IT BACK AS A BREATH PATTERN

Before you send it: no two inhales without an exhale between them, nothing longer than ninety minutes, an outdoor break in every half-day, and the last working block is always commitments. If the pattern reads flat on paper, it will feel flat in the room.

The venue & logistics checklist.

Walk this list before you sign anything. The items people miss are almost always A/V, breakout space and accessibility — and all three are expensive to fix on the day.

Space

- ☐ Main room fits the group in the layout you actually want
- ☐ A breakout space or two
- ☐ Natural light — a room you won't hate by 3pm
- ☐ Quiet space for a call or a breather

A/V & power

- ☐ Screen, projector or TV, HDMI + adapters
- ☐ Mics for any room over ~25 people
- ☐ Reliable Wi-Fi and enough outlets
- ☐ Someone who can fix it fast if it fails

Food & comfort

- ☐ Meals and breaks ordered; dietary needs covered
- ☐ Coffee that doesn't run out
- ☐ Rooming list, if it's overnight
- ☐ Water in the room — all day

People & access

- ☐ Travel, directions and parking sent
- ☐ Accessibility needs asked about — and met
- ☐ Materials, name tents, printouts
- ☐ A named point person on the day

What lets you run the day you designed BECAUSE OF PAGES 2-5

- ☐ A kitchen or prep space you are allowed to use
- ☐ A thermostat you can actually control
- ☐ Outdoor space within a two-minute walk
- ☐ Furniture you have permission to move
- ☐ Somewhere to eat that is not the working room
- ☐ Permission to bring your own food in

ONE MORE THING

Ask the venue what e/se is booked that day. A wedding setup in the next ballroom has ruined more debriefs than bad Wi-Fi.

Prep timeline & budget worksheet.

WHEN	WHAT
6 weeks out	Sponsor alignment (Step 1), dates locked, venue held, provider briefed
4 weeks out	Agenda drafted, invites out, travel + rooming, F&B ordered
2 weeks out	Final headcount, run-of-show, pre-reads sent, A/V confirmed
Week of	Print materials, brief facilitators, send the logistics email
After	Send the commitments + photos within 48 hours; schedule the 30-day check-in

Budget worksheet

LINE ITEM	EST.	ACTUAL
Venue / meeting space		
Food & beverage		
A/V & production		
Facilitation / team experience		
Travel & lodging		
Materials & misc.		
Contingency (~10%)		
Total		

WHERE THE MONEY ACTUALLY MATTERS

Rooms and food are table stakes; nobody remembers either. The line that decides whether the offsite gets talked about next year is **facilitation and the shared experience**. If something has to give, give somewhere else.

The 30 days after decide whether it was worth it.

Most offsites die on the flight home. Three moves keep the commitments alive — and none of them takes more than fifteen minutes.

Within 48 hours

Send the commitments exactly as people said them — names, owners, dates — plus the photos.

Week 2

One prompt to each person: what's one thing you've done differently since?

Day 30

A 30-minute check-in: what held, what slipped, what we're changing. Calendar it before you leave.

FREE · USE IT WITH YOUR TEAM

The 30-Day Challenge

Day 30 lands better when it isn't a surprise. Before anyone leaves the room, each person names one behaviour they'll do daily — small, specific, entirely in their own control — and tracks it for thirty days. Private by default. We send the nudges and keep the count, so what's measured is improvement in the behaviour they chose.

30
DAYS

challenge.
belegendary.org →

MAKE THE OFFSITE THE PART THEY REMEMBER

We'll bring the experience that makes it *land*.

You've got the plan handled. The piece that turns a good agenda into an offsite people talk about for years is the shared experience in the middle — and that's exactly what we do. We come to your venue, anywhere in the country.

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